PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

AM General Hummer H1

1992–2006 · HMMWV-based · 6.2 / 6.5 / 6.5 TD · 5.7 V8 · Alpha 6.6 Duramax

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Cold-start the turbo diesel and check the coolant**
  1996 to early-1999 6.5 turbo diesels can crack at the No. 8 cylinder. Flash Off-Road's test: with the engine stone cold, open the radiator cap, run the engine for about a minute, shut it off and open the cap again. Pressure in the coolant, foaming at the bleeder once it's warm, or milky sludge in the CDR valve point to a cracked block or head gasket. A 'Z' in the fourth VIN digit is a GM-built turbo engine; an 'F' is the later AM General engine.

- [ ] **Front-end play**
  Flash Off-Road calls the front end the H1's biggest weakness: idler arms, pitman arms and steering gears wear out. With the engine running, if the steering wheel moves an inch or two before the front wheels do, suspect the pitman arm. If the steering turns more easily one way than the other, suspect the steering box. Uneven tire wear points to worn front-end parts or a bad alignment.

- [ ] **Geared-hub and halfshaft leaks**
  A fan of oil sprayed on the inside of a tire means a leaking hub seal. So does a CTIS that won't hold air, through the spindle seal. Look for torn halfshaft boots, and wet spots where the shafts meet the differentials and hubs. Wet calipers can be differential oil, because the brakes sit right next to the differentials.

- [ ] **Make the CTIS work**
  Run the pump on the fronts, the rears and all four, and watch the cab gauge. Owners do abandon CTIS when the pump dies, and Flash Off-Road says a new pump can cost well over $1,000. Retrofitting CTIS, the four-speed transmission or the second fuel tank to a truck that lacks them is hard and rarely worth it, so buy the features you want.

- [ ] **Transfer case fluid and the 'vampire'**
  Pull the transfer case fill plug. If fluid pours out, the cooler loop inside the case may be leaking transmission fluid into it, the 'vampire' that AM General addressed with customer-satisfaction campaign R0101 in 2001. Brown, burnt fluid is a sign of long stretches at 80 mph. Flash Off-Road recommends keeping it under about 65 mph (2,400 rpm).

- [ ] **Heater and A/C: pre- or post-1997.5**
  The HVAC system used from 1994 leaked heater cores and was replaced from VIN 176477 (the '97.5'). Flash Off-Road says the old parts are discontinued and the upgrade runs $3,000 to $4,000. Upgraded systems use a vacuum-controlled heater valve and lack separate recirculate and A/C buttons on the control head.

- [ ] **Correct wheels and tires**
  Every H1 wheel uses an 8×6.5-in bolt pattern with a 7-in backset. Flash Off-Road says only AM General and GT/Cepek wheels have the right offset and load rating. Wrong wheels stress the front end, need custom CTIS lines and throw dirt up the sides. Tires for 16.5-in wheels are scarce, so check the spare.

- [ ] **Body, rockers and underside**
  The body is aluminum but the doors and wagon top are steel. Expect some corrosion where the two meet and around the marker lights, and lift the wheel-well carpet on wagons to check the inner seams. Look for bent rockers and undercarriage protection pushed up against the exhaust, which comes from off-road use.

YEARS TO KNOW

1998	SWEET SPOT	Flash Off-Road says many consider it the quintessential pre-Alpha H1: 2.56 axles, cam camber adjustment, quieter hubs, and the last Torsen I year before ABS. But '97–'98 turbo diesels are the most common No. 8 crack years, so test the block
2004	SWEET SPOT	'Optimizer' 6.5 turbo diesel with Caterpillar-built ECM (205 hp, 440 lb-ft); all-new interior; optional front and rear Eaton lockers. Flash Off-Road calls it the best stock truck yet. No 2005 model year follows
2006	SWEET SPOT	H1 Alpha: 6.6 Duramax (300 hp, 520 lb-ft), Allison five-speed, 2-in body lift, helical-gear hubs, 12-in brakes, 51 gal of fuel. 729 built; production ends June 2006

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Engine-cover insulation chafing fuel return hose and wiring**
  1992–1993 · NHTSA 94V-162
- [ ] **Fuel-pump oil pressure switch missing seal**
  1992–1994 · NHTSA 94V-164
- [ ] **Cruise control cable can freeze**
  1994–1995 · NHTSA 95V-023
- [ ] **Fuel tank can expand into the propshaft**
  1995 · NHTSA 95V-161
- [ ] **Accelerator pedal shaft corrosion**
  1992–1996 · NHTSA 96V-049
- [ ] **Master cylinder fastened with metric nuts**
  1999 · NHTSA 99V-059
- [ ] **Brake lines chafing between master cylinder and ABS modulator**
  1999–2000 · NHTSA 00V-005
- [ ] **Turn signals fail to cancel**
  1998–2000 · NHTSA 01V-336
- [ ] **Wrong steering-gear mounting hardware**
  2006 · NHTSA 06V-377

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **VIN engine and transmission codes**
  Fourth digit is the engine: X = 6.2 diesel, Y = 6.5 non-turbo diesel, Z = GM 6.5 turbo diesel, F = 6.5 turbo diesel with Caterpillar ECM, D/L = 5.7 L05 gas, W = 350 gas. Fifth digit: E = 3L80 three-speed, A = 4L80-E four-speed. On the 2006 Alpha the fourth digit is P (Duramax) and the fifth H (Allison).
- [ ] **VIN body and year codes**
  Digits 6–7 give the body: 82 VLC2 two-door truck, 83 HMC4 four-door truck, 84 HMCS wagon, 85 VLCO open top, 86 HMCF fleet, 87/88 Recruit, 89 XLC2 extended cab, 90 HMCO open top with full hard doors. Digit 10 is the model year (N = 1992 … 4 = 2004, 6 = 2006) and digit 11 is the plant (E = Mishawaka).
- [ ] **Spotting an Alpha**
  A square intake cap in place of the round 'mushroom', a Duramax badge on the hood, a hood hinged at the bottom center, a brush guard without its top bar, and a black block-off strip above the rear bumper filling the 2-in body-lift gap. Wave 2 trucks (from September 2005, first VIN 6E226861) have an all-black interior.

- [ ] **Torsen type and axle ratio**
  Differential covers normally carry a tag with the ratio and Torsen type. Otherwise read the ring-gear tooth count: 41/15 is 2.73:1, 41/16 is 2.56:1. All trucks through 1998 have Torsen I; 1998 is the only Torsen I truck with 2.56 gears.
- [ ] **Old or upgraded HVAC**
  Pre-'97.5 control heads have extra recirculate and A/C buttons and an electric heater valve. The upgraded system uses a vacuum-controlled heater valve, with small colored vacuum tubes behind the control head.
- [ ] **6.5 block casting**
  The definitive check for the improved No. 8-cylinder block is the casting number, readable only with the engine cover off: C-159 (March 15, 1999) and later are the revised design.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/hummer/h1/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks